Helping students explain subject knowledge in English

Practical guide for subject lecturers | D11-S1–S6

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Students may understand a concept but find it difficult to organise an explanation or express relationships accurately in English. Show them what an effective explanation requires in your subject, provide opportunities to practise and give focused feedback.

1. Make the structure of an explanation explicit

Identify the parts students need to include for the particular task. Display a few prompts to guide their thinking.

Example — Engineering

1. Identify the fault → Explain its effect on the circuit → Support the explanation with test results
2. Explain what each part contributes: "Naming the faulty component tells us what you think happened. Explaining its effect shows your understanding of the circuit. The test results provide evidence for your conclusion."
3. Choose a structure suited to the task. Explaining a process, interpreting results and justifying a decision may require different arrangements.

2. Model an explanation and unpack its features

Provide a short spoken or written explanation using course content. Point out how it connects the central idea, reasoning and evidence.

Example — Business

"Profit fell because costs increased by more than revenue. Revenue rose by £20,000, while costs rose by £30,000. This reduced profit by £10,000."

Explain your choices:

Part of the explanation	What it does
"Profit fell because costs increased by more than revenue."	States the main explanation.
"Revenue rose by £20,000, while costs rose by £30,000."	Provides supporting figures and compares them.
"This reduced profit by £10,000."	Connects the figures to the outcome.

Then ask students to identify the same features in another explanation.

3. Provide language for expressing key relationships

Select two or three optional phrases that match the reasoning students need. Demonstrate them using your subject content.

Relationship	Possible wording
Cause and effect	"This leads to… because…"
Comparison	"Both… However…"
Evidence and interpretation	"The results suggest… because…"
Conditions or limits	"This applies when…"; "This may…"

Explain that wording must match the strength of the evidence.

Example — Public health
"'Is associated with' describes a relationship. 'Causes' makes a stronger claim. Choose the wording your evidence supports."

Students can use their own expressions. The aim is to make their reasoning clear and accurate.

4. Use diagrams or other representations to support explanation

Ask students to organise their understanding in a diagram, table, equation or annotated image. Then show how to use it as a plan for explaining.

How to do it

1. Choose a representation suited to the concept.
2. Ask students to label the important features.
3. Have them indicate relationships, such as sequence, cause or contrast.
4. Ask them to explain those relationships in words.

Example — Biology
Students label the stages of a process and add arrows showing their sequence.

Prompt: “Use your diagram to explain what happens at each stage and how it connects to the next. Explain the relationships, rather than only reading the labels.”

Check the representation for conceptual accuracy before students build a fuller explanation from it.

5. Build in rehearsal and revision

Give students time to prepare and try an explanation before sharing it more widely.

Example — Business

1. Ask students to explain why profit fell despite higher revenue.
2. Tasks:
   a. Speaker’s task: “Prepare a one-minute explanation. You can use brief notes or the figures.”
   b. Listener’s task: “Check whether the explanation connects revenue, costs and profit. Identify one clear point and one point that needs clarification.”
3. After the exchange, give students time to revise. They can then explain again, change partners or turn the explanation into a short paragraph.
4. Keep the listener’s task focused on the subject reasoning and clarity; students do not need to correct each other’s grammar.

6. Give focused feedback on meaning and clarity

First establish what the student means. Then identify whether the main difficulty concerns subject understanding, organisation or wording.

Main difficulty	Possible teacher response
Subject understanding	"Check the direction of the relationship against the graph. Does your explanation match the results?"
Organisation	"State your main explanation first, then use the figures to support it."
Wording	"Do you mean that this factor caused the change, or that the two were associated? Choose wording that makes your intended claim clear."

Address one or two important points, then ask students to revise the relevant sentence or section.

Example — Environmental science
"You have named the factors. Now explain how one factor affects the outcome. Add that connection, then explain it again."

Evaluate the revised explanation against the same subject expectations. Focus language feedback on features that affect meaning or are explicitly required by the task.

A short routine to try
For one concept in your next lesson:

1. Display the parts an explanation needs.
2. Model a short explanation and identify its features.
3. Offer a few useful phrases or a visual planning tool.
4. Let students rehearse with a partner.
5. Give focused feedback and time to revise.

Supporting sources

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